

# Student Loan Help

Federal student loan rules keep changing — but you have real options to lower your payments and, for many people, get loans forgiven. Everything official is free at StudentAid.gov. Tick the box once you've looked into each one.

## ⚠ BEFORE YOU START

You never have to pay a company to manage or "forgive" your federal student loans — every application is free at StudentAid.gov. The SAVE repayment plan ended by court order in 2026, so ignore any site still promoting it.

## 1 Start Here — Your Federal Loan Account

StudentAid.gov is the official site for everything: your balance, your servicer, repayment plans, and forgiveness applications.

### ☐ StudentAid.gov — Your Dashboard

Log in to see your loans, your servicer, and your options. The starting point for everything below.

→ [studentaid.gov](https://studentaid.gov)

### ☐ Loan Simulator — Compare Plans

A free tool that estimates your payments under each repayment plan and shows which fits your situation.

→ [studentaid.gov/loan-simulator](https://studentaid.gov/loan-simulator)

## 2 Lower Your Monthly Payment

Income-driven repayment (IDR) sets your payment based on income and family size. After 20–25 years of payments, the rest may be forgiven.

### ☐ Income-Driven Repayment (IDR)

Apply for an income-based plan. IBR is the main one being processed right now; a new plan (RAP) is being added. Apply free.

→ [studentaid.gov/manage-loans/repayment/plans/income-driven](https://studentaid.gov/manage-loans/repayment/plans/income-driven)

### ☐ Trouble Paying? Deferment & Forbearance

If you can't pay right now, you may pause payments. Ask your servicer, but know interest may still build up.

→ [studentaid.gov/manage-loans/lower-payments/get-temporary-relief](https://studentaid.gov/manage-loans/lower-payments/get-temporary-relief)

### 3 Get Your Loans Forgiven

Several forgiveness programs written into law are still active and discharging loans in 2026.

☐ **Public Service Loan Forgiveness (PSLF)**

Work full-time for government or a 501(c)(3) nonprofit? Your remaining balance can be forgiven after 120 qualifying payments. Use the PSLF Help Tool.

→ [studentaid.gov/pslf](https://studentaid.gov/pslf)

☐ **Teacher Loan Forgiveness**

Teach 5 years in a low-income school and you may get up to \$17,500 forgiven.

→ [studentaid.gov/manage-loans/forgiveness-cancellation/teacher](https://studentaid.gov/manage-loans/forgiveness-cancellation/teacher)

☐ **Disability & Closed School Discharge**

Loans can be discharged if you have a total and permanent disability, or your school closed. Both still accept applications.

→ [studentaid.gov/manage-loans/forgiveness-cancellation](https://studentaid.gov/manage-loans/forgiveness-cancellation)

### 4 If You're Behind or in Default

Being behind isn't the end of the road — there are official ways to get back on track and protect your wages and tax refund.

☐ **Get Out of Default**

Options like loan rehabilitation can restore your loan to good standing. Start with your servicer or StudentAid.gov.

→ [studentaid.gov/manage-loans/default/get-out](https://studentaid.gov/manage-loans/default/get-out)

☐ **Free Help & Complaints (FSA Ombudsman)**

Free federal help if you're stuck with your servicer or have a dispute.

→ [studentaid.gov/feedback-ombudsman/disputes/prepare](https://studentaid.gov/feedback-ombudsman/disputes/prepare)

**⚠ WATCH OUT FOR**

Never pay a company that promises fast “loan forgiveness” for a fee — the FTC has shut down many of these. Everything they offer, you can do yourself for free at StudentAid.gov. The SAVE plan is no longer available.

**★ A TIP THAT HELPS**

Even if forgiveness feels far off, getting on an income-driven plan now can drop your payment to an affordable amount — sometimes very low — and start your forgiveness clock.

**NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?**

**Ask for your personalized student-loan search**

Student loan rules shift often. For help understanding your specific loans, your servicer, or which plan is best for you right now, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll walk through it with you.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID

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